

Keynote Address

**MARGINS OF TRUST:
THE INFORMAL ECONOMY,
INCLUSION, AND THE
FUTURE OF WEST AFRICAN
COMMERCE**
By

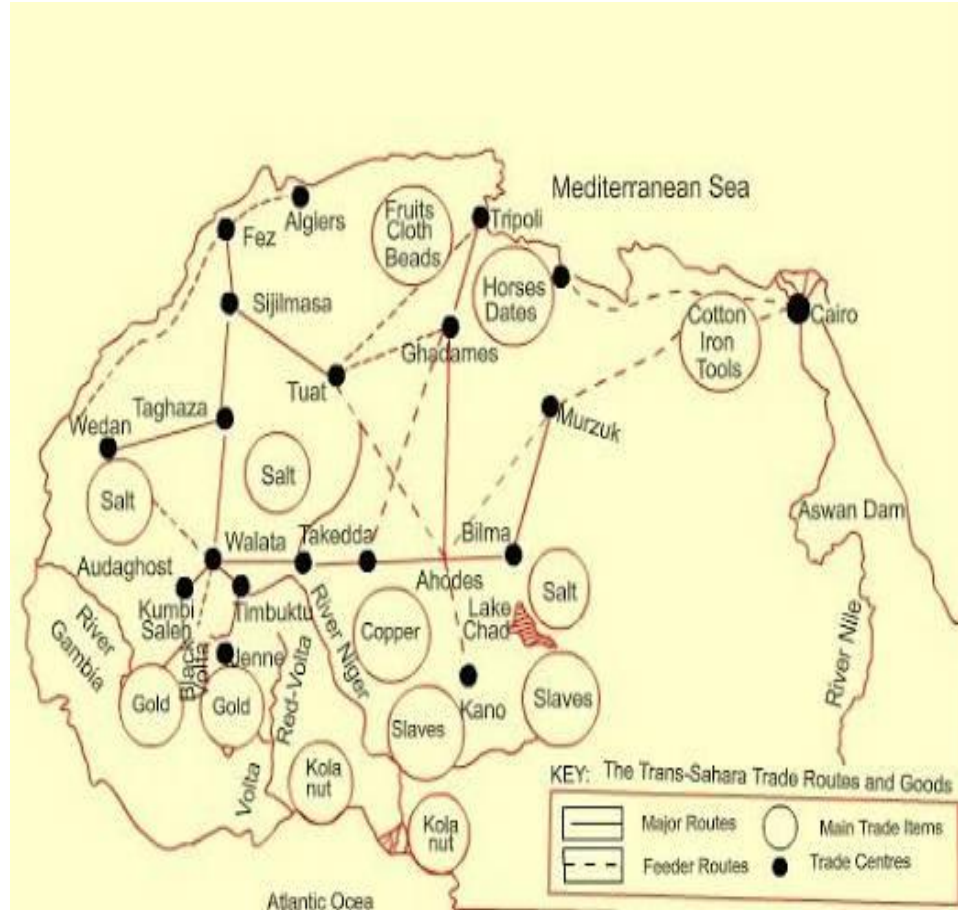
Farouk Gumel

*Vice Chairman, TGI
Group*

*Route To Market West Africa
2026*



The Trans-Saharan Trade Route



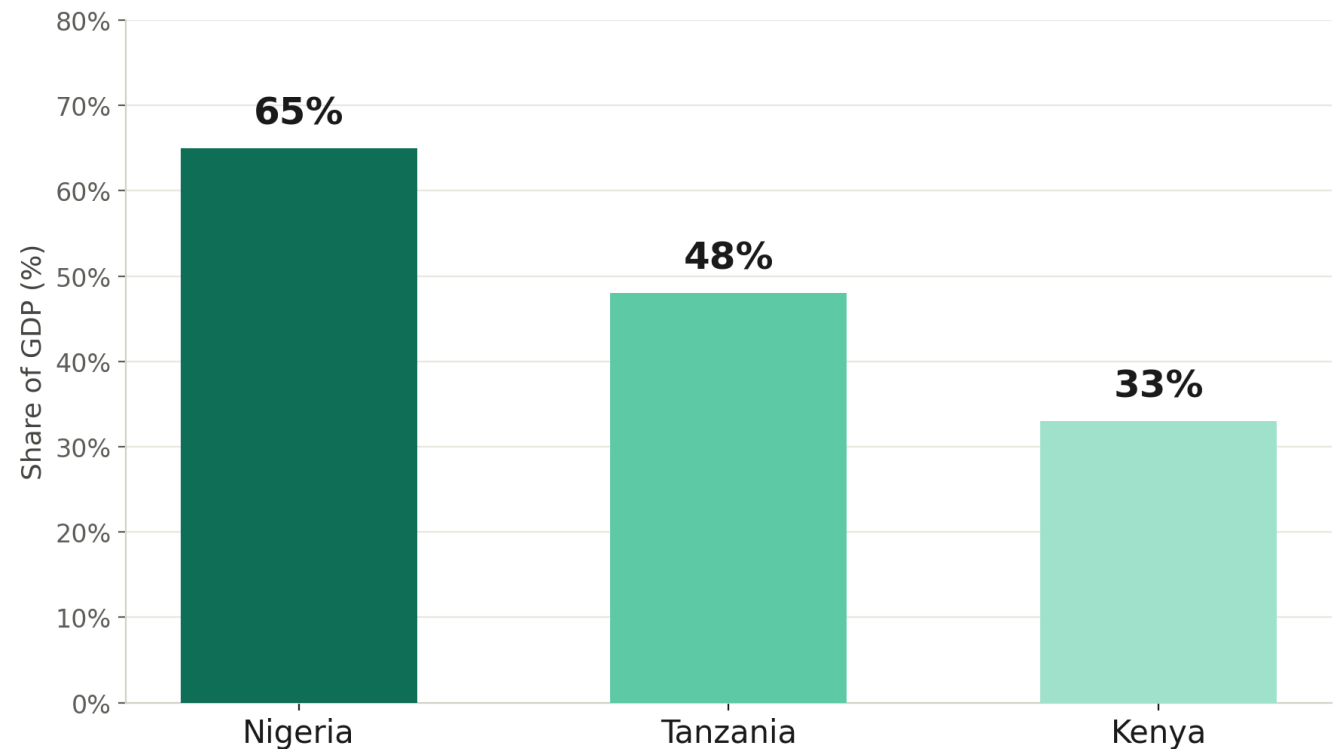
**BEFORE DASHBOARDS ,
BEFORE CONTRACTS**

The
infrastructure
of trust has
always been
there. We just
stopped counting
it.



Informal Sector Share of GDP

Selected African Economies

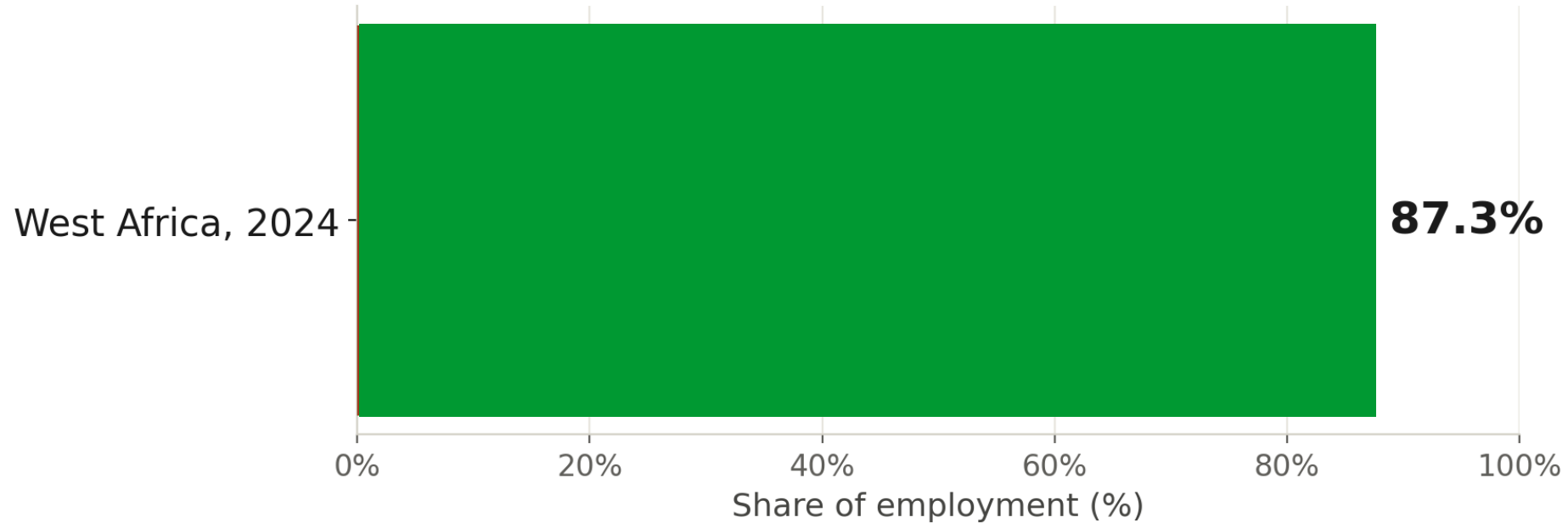


Across West Africa, the large majority of jobs sit outside the formal economy

Source: United Nations Economic Commission for Africa, "Socioeconomic Profile of West Africa, 2024," November 2024. The West African average informal employment rate stood at 87.3% in 2024, higher than the equivalent statistic for Africa as a whole.

Informal Employment Share, West Africa

Across West Africa, the large majority of jobs sit outside the formal economy



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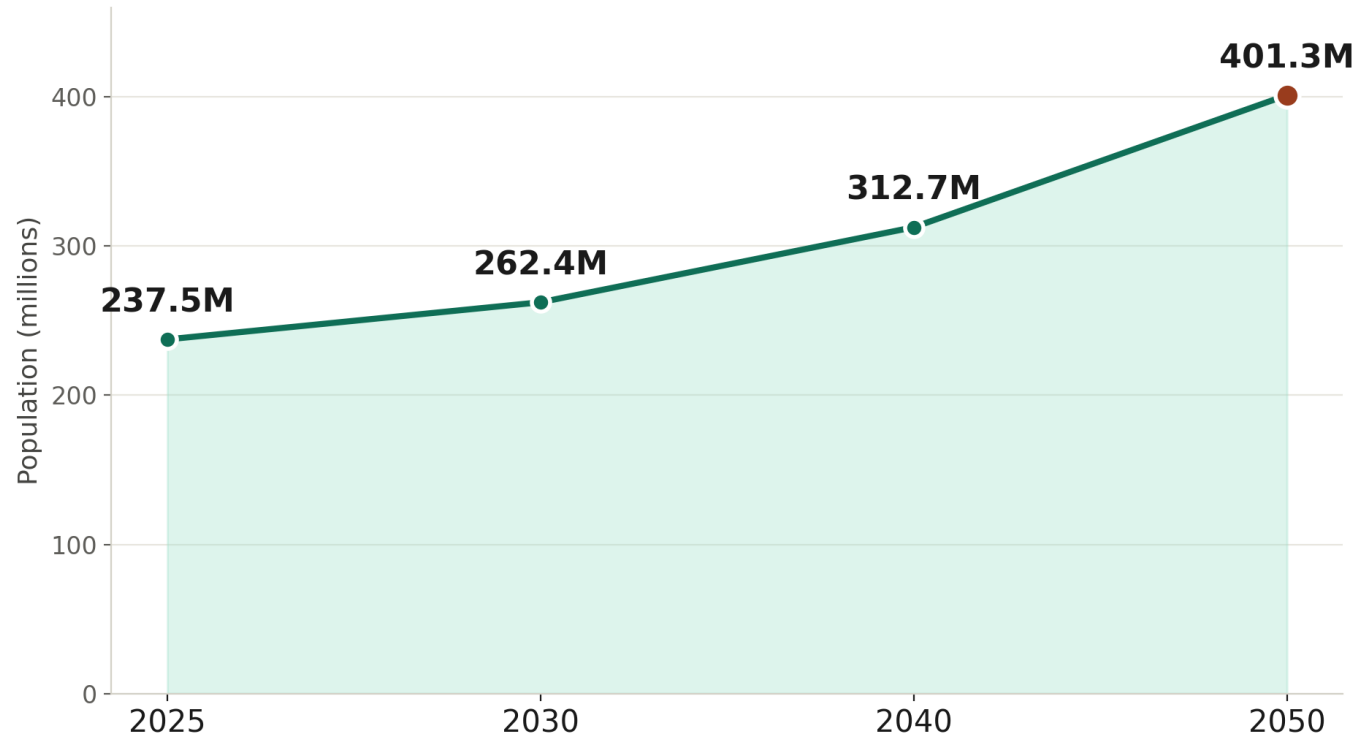
When shocks hit and they hit often what keeps the goods moving is not a bank guarantee or a service level agreement. It is trust.



A community with
no stake in your
success has no
incentive to
protect your
investment.



Nigeria's Projected Population Growth by 2050



Nigeria is on track to become the world's third most populous country by 2050

Source: UN World Population Prospects (medium variant), as cited by UNFPA Nigeria Country Programme Document and Intelpoint demographic analysis, 2025. UNFPA projects Nigeria's population will reach 400 million by 2050, making it the world's third most populous country.

The Trust Economy Model

The invisible architecture

MARGINS OF

1



*Relational
Capital*

2



*Flow of
Informal*

3



*Community
Embeddedness*

The next decade belongs to
companies that build bridges,
not walls. Those that listen
instead of those that impose.

*STOP
OPTIMISING
FOR
EFFICIENCY
IN
ENVIRONMENTS
THAT DEMAND
RESILIENCE.*

*STOP
TRUSTING
DASHBOARDS
MORE THAN
YOU TRUST
PEOPLE.*

*STOP TREATING
THE INFORMAL
ECONOMY AS A
PROBLEM TO BE
SOLVED, AND
START
TREATING IT
AS
INTELLIGENCE
TO BE DECODED*

*Do not mistake inclusion for
charity. Rural inclusion is not
corporate benevolence.
It is commercial strategy.*

*It is how you build the demand that you will later serve. It is how
you earn the right to grow.*

Trust is not soft value.
Trust is the
margin.



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